# Educators' Perspectives on the Socialization of Stigma and Acceptance for Children with Disabilities in the U.S., Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan

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## Overview of the research

### Research Questions

- How do educators socialize children to minimize stigma and facilitate acceptance for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities?
- What are similarities and differences across cultures?

### Children with Mild Cognitive and Behavioral Disabilities

- Their diagnoses include learning disabilities, ADHD, & high-functioning autism.
- They appear "normal and healthy" and in many areas, function well.
- Their behaviors may be misinterpreted as laziness, disobedience, & disrespect.
- They may be at risk for delay in receipt of services and educational neglect.
- These disabilities are recognized as "high-incidence" disabilities in the U.S.
- The number of children identified as having mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities has increased over the last decade in East Asian countries.

### Conceptual Framework

- Peers, educators, & parents play important roles in children's co-construction of positive/negative attitudes toward disability and in supporting children with disabilities within their classrooms (e.g., Varenne & McDermott, 1998).
- "Universalism without uniformity": Understand cultural variations through issues commonly addressed in every culture, e.g., "disability" (Shweder & Sullivan, 1993).

### Methods

- Semi-structured, audio-recorded individual in-depth interviews with educators
- Participants described their experiences working with children with disabilities.
- All data were collected and analyzed in participants' native language.
- Using analytic induction techniques, the meanings of participants' experiences were interpreted through repeated readings of transcribed interviews (Schwandt, 2007).
- Cross-cultural variations and similarities were examined through on-going discussion among researchers (Shweder & Sullivan, 1993).

### Participants

**Japan:** **26 educators** from 4 suburban areas in Japan
[20 females; **2-40 years** of experience]
**South Korea:** **43 educators** in a metropolitan area
[41 females; **6-40 years** of experience]
**Taiwan:** **14 educators** in a metropolitan area
[14 females: **10-30 years** of experience]
**U.S.:** **18 educators** in a suburban area
[15 females: **2-33 years** of experience]



### Socio-cultural, Historical & Policy Context

- Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan share relatively common beliefs about disability influenced by Confucianism, Buddhism, and animism.
- They also have been influenced by special education policies from Western countries, including the U.S.
- Yet the implementation of special education systems vary in each country.

### The Importance of Peers as Reflected in Policies

- Explicit agenda in East Asian countries
  - The "whole person" perspective and personality development of children
  - Relationships of children with disabilities and typically-developing peers are mutually beneficial.
- Implicit agenda in the U.S.
  - No explicit description regarding peers' roles in the education of children with disabilities

## Results & Discussion

### Common issues addressed in four sites

*Peers' reactions influence children's experience of stigma*

- Teachers in four sites commonly addressed children with disabilities who internalized stigma caused by their disabilities or "differences," e.g., feeling ashamed, worrying about their peers' reactions, etc.

*Teachers create a "kind" classroom atmosphere*

- In four sites, teachers teach and guide children to create a positive classroom atmosphere.
- Children's reactions to peers with disabilities change with their development.
  - Younger children are more accepting.

*Help children understand their peers with disabilities and include them*

- Teachers commonly facilitate positive interactions, e.g., by educating and encouraging typically-developing children to understand and help their peers with disabilities.

*Teachers use metaphor to help peers understand struggles of children with disabilities*

- Teachers in four sites used a variety of metaphors, e.g., "cup of tolerance", "thinking pockets," "cookies with different colors," and "different size of shoes" so that children can understand and respect individual differences.

### Cultural variations

#### Japan

- Less stigma for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities than for those with other types of disabilities
- Classroom teachers prefer to provide extra support for children with disabilities as "naturally" as possible.
- Educators may involve typically-developing peers in the support for children with disabilities.
- Relatively ambiguous special education policies allow flexibility and creativity in the support for children with disabilities, e.g., utilize problems children are facing as an opportunity for them to learn
- Educators described how they provide support so it does not look "special" to typically-developing peers.



***"If there is a child with a disability, other children grow… There are children who look at them as 'special' but [we try] to make it in a way that has positive impacts, and raises other children's kokoro [heart and mind]."***

#### South Korea

***"Children in my classroom, especially girls, seem to take care of [a child with a disability] like a baby, just like their mothers [did to them]. When the child acted out, the girls took the child back to his chair. … [They] really enjoy helping [the child]."***



- Sensitivity to stigma is strong.
- Educators focus on developing disability awareness programs to promote positive perspectives on children with disabilities.
- Educators explicitly encourage children to understand the struggles of their peers with disabilities.
- South Korea has developed a structured special education system (e.g., clear roles for general and special education teachers.)
- Educators described peers' sensitivity to teachers' responses to children with disabilities rather than the "differences" caused by their disabilities.

#### Taiwan

- Mixed reactions to children's mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities.
  - Some people have prejudice but some do not.
  - Some parents are not able to accept their children's disabilities. Educators are sensitive enough to help them.
- Educators tell peers explicitly that the child has a disability and encourage them to help him/her
- Taiwan has implemented "humanistic inclusive education," which allows flexibility in supporting children.
- Educators have developed their own strategies to handle the disruptive behaviors of children with disabilities, e.g., praising and "shaming" strategies.

***"I would not tell children about what his disability is. … I told them he would make a lot of mistakes, but all people would make mistakes, even Confucius did."***



#### U.S.

***"I know it stinks to have them pulled out of class so much but… it just really does help. You can see…they do make a lot of progress that they probably wouldn't have made [in their general ed. classrooms]."***

- Benefits of receiving special education may outweigh stigma for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities.
- Educators recognized that children's peer group memberships as an important learning context.
- Educators utilize a variety of strategies to facilitate positive interaction between children with disabilities and typically-developing peers to minimize stigma.
- The U.S. has established relatively fixed and structured special education systems with clear procedural guidelines.
- Special education policies have been shifting toward more classroom-based support from individually based interventions provided by specialists.

### Summary

- In four sites, educators have experienced the recent transition of special education systems involving support for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities.
- Findings suggest both cultural variation and similarities across four sites.
- In four sites, typically-developing peers played important roles in the support for children with mild cognitive and behavioral disabilities. Yet their beliefs, experiences and practices are culturally nuanced.

### Implications for educators & practitioners

- East Asian cases provide U.S. educators with new perspectives to develop intervention programs for children from culturally diverse communities, including immigrant families.
- U.S. cases provide educators in East Asian countries a general framework to provide systematic and consistent interventions.